

# *A long lunch with von der Leyen*

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## 【メール原文】

Presented by Connect Europe By GABRIEL GAVIN with MAX GRIERA and GREGORIO SORGI GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin. Are you a top official who sometimes

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GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin. Are you a top official who sometimes feels like you live at the Berlaymont? Now you more or less can, with a one-bedroom apartment hideously close to the Commission headquarters going for the low price of €1,250 a month. Just don't expect to make friends with the neighbors ...

START HERE — SCOOP: A group of countries led by Germany is reviving the row over using frozen Russian assets to fund Ukraine, pitching a new loan for Kyiv supported by the assets. That would replace at least some of the €100 billion planned for Ukraine in the EU's upcoming budget, in line with Berlin's aim of radically cutting the budget overall, four diplomats and officials told Hans von der Burchard, Nick Vinocur and Gregorio Sorigi.

Tough choices: Belgium, which hosts the bulk of the frozen funds, fears it would bear the burden of any legal challenge by Russia and shot down a similar plan last year. But one of the diplomats said the move is seen as preferable to slashing planned spending elsewhere. "It confronts countries like Belgium with the question whether they want to finance Ukraine support via the [budget], meaning there may be less money for farmers and regions, or whether they free up many billions by using the Russian assets instead," they said.

In today's Playbook:

— Ursula von der Leyen is testing the appetite for what she's cooking up in the State of the Union.

— From craft beer to women's basketball, we've got everything you need to know for this weekend in Brussels.

— Faces in the crowd: Hildegard Bentele, Niclas Herbst, Enrico Bocedi, Stine Bosse, Ekrem İmamoğlu, Mario Draghi, Ulf Kristersson, Siegfried Murekhan, Bernie Sanders, Sandro Gozi and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender Podcast: Sarah, Joanna, Nick and Laurens discuss whether Europe is winning (or losing) the "fight" von der Leyen vowed to confront in last year's SOTEU.

## POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

**\*\***A message from Connect Europe: AI, cloud services, secure communications and connected industries all depend on telecom networks, but Europe's operators still lack the scale and investment conditions to compete globally. Our DG Alessandro Gropelli explains why stronger telecoms are essential to Europe's economy, security and independence. Read the article. **\*\***

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## DRIVING THE DAY

**THE UNION'S IN A STATE:** EU countries will today tell Commission President Ursula von der Leyen to use her State of the Union speech on Wednesday to commit to turning around the bloc's flagging economy and tackle immigration — as public discontent drives up support for far-right parties across the continent.

Political appetite: Ambassadors from the 27 countries have been invited for a lunch with von der Leyen in the exclusive dining room on the 13th floor of the Berlaymont, off limits to ordinary staffers and catered by a team of top chefs.

On the agenda: While von der Leyen's best-trailed policy announcements were on social affairs and geopolitical issues, including a social media "delay" for children under 13 and finding financial support for Ukraine, national governments seem to have other things on their minds. The speech comes two years after ex-ECB boss Mario Draghi predicted "slow agony" for the EU if it didn't take action to support key industries — and, with the president entering the twilight of her time in office, little has been delivered to solve the crisis, according to POLITICO research.

Ambassadors will likely raise economic growth, job creation, the single market, competitiveness, cutting red tape and protecting Europe's borders, five diplomats from across the bloc and two officials (granted anonymity to speak frankly) told Playbook. The push comes as von der Leyen faces flak from some quarters for her handling of growing concerns about borrowing costs, public spending and debt.

"We see the economy isn't working for people ... this is what is driving the surge of the far right," said Petros Fassoulas, secretary-general of the European Movement, which brings together pro-EU politicians to campaign on key issues. "We are running out of opportunities to demonstrate to our fellow citizens that politics, democracy, Europe, can deliver answers."

What do they want? "We can only show that we can deliver, by actually delivering," said Hildegard Bentele, a German MEP from Friedrich Merz's CDU. "That means concretely improving the conditions for businesses and citizens, like cutting red tape, lowering costs and improving infrastructure and security."

Seeing red over green: A handful of countries, including the Czech Republic and Poland, want von der Leyen to further relax green legislation like the Emissions Trading System to ease pressure on heavy

industry. Meanwhile, right-wing EPP and ECR lawmakers have revived a bid to scrap carbon rules if prices rise. A rival faction, led by Sweden and the Baltics, says that doing so would undercut companies that have already invested in the clean transition.

New arrivals: A coalition of countries, led by Denmark and Italy, is pushing for stronger powers to crack down on migration to avoid the issue fueling the extreme right, three of the diplomats said. But, with a package of measures already signed off and illegal crossing figures falling, von der Leyen will have to dig deep to find something new to say on the subject.

NOW READ THIS: From heavyweight lobbyists to cash-strapped NGOs, outside groups are jostling to get a line in the State of the Union, Mari Eccles and Sebastian Starcevic report.

## BIG AND BREAKING

SWEDISH THRILLER: Sunday's election in Sweden is going down to the wire, with the opposition center-left bloc leading incumbent Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson's right-wing alliance by just 2.6 percentage points, according to pollster Novus — within the margin of error.

INTERFERENCE WARNING: Russia poses a threat to upcoming elections across Europe and social media platforms need to step up the fight against Moscow's bots, Sweden's disinformation defense chief tells my colleague Tim Ross in Stockholm.

ON THE FRONT LINE: Poland averted a "direct threat" to its border crossing with Ukraine on Wednesday night and is expecting more incidents as a result of Russia's war, Prime Minister Donald Tusk has warned.

THE FAR RIGHT'S SECRET TO SUCCESS: Parties looking to capitalize on public anger are learning that the more radical they are, the more people seem to vote for them, Marion Solletty reports.

IS AI GOING TO KILL US ALL? Maybe, but Brussels isn't worried about it just yet, Pieter Haeck writes.

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## FAR-RIGHT FIREWALL

CROSSING THE RUBICON: The European People's Party's decision to work with the right and far right on a key spending file is inflaming divisions in the European Parliament — and threatening to derail negotiations on the bloc's next long-term budget, Max Grier and Gregorio Sorgi report.

The flashpoint: Despite vowing to keep the far right out of budget negotiations, EPP MEPs last week used their support to push through an opinion on a file setting the rules for how EU money is spent, tracked and evaluated. The liberals, Socialists and Democrats and Greens wanted to retain green conditions and gender-mainstreaming requirements, while the EPP wanted to water them down.

The opinion is due to go before Parliament's plenary next week. It won't become law, but it will feed into the final legislation, which is still under negotiation. Now "we know what's coming," Danish Renew MEP Stine Bosse said, warning that the EPP will push to remove the green requirements.

Budget threat: Jean-Marc Germain, the S&D's lead negotiator on the final text, said he wouldn't take the opinion into account and would instead work with centrist groups. "This piece of legislation is key for the S&D. If it is weakened, it will lead to the S&D rejecting the entire [EU budget]," he warned.

EPP negotiator Niclas Herbst said he'd seek "broad support," while urging the S&D to be "more open to cooperation and compromise." Siegfried Mureşan, the group's lead MEP on the overall budget, said the EPP remained "committed to a centrist majority" and that the far right would not become a "broader tendency" in budget talks. EPP group Chair Manfred Weber declined to comment.

The vote shows the difficulty of enforcing the firewall across a broad political group — and underlines that whether the EPP keeps the far right at arm's length can come down to individual MEPs. With the long-term budget spread across dozens of files and committees, center-left lawmakers fear that similar cooperation could emerge elsewhere.

## 20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The EU ombudsman yesterday launched a probe into Ursula von der Leyen's pick as special envoy on AI , but what does the ombudsman do? The office investigates complaints made against EU institutions, agencies and bodies, and looks into claims of the likes of unfair conduct, abuse of power and discrimination. Anyone can make a complaint to the ombudsman, or the watchdog can start its own investigations. The European Parliament picks the ombudsman for a five-year term, which can be renewed. The current office-holder is Teresa Anjinho.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

## CONSULTANCY CONUNDRUM

ETHICAL DILEMMA: What do you do when you land a Brussels public affairs job — and hate the idea of representing a particular client? It's a problem that's especially acute for junior staffers, according to five consultants who spoke to Mari Eccles for our sister newsletter, EU Influence . "You kind of have to take what you're given," one of them said, because "you just need to get out of the intern trap."

"I remember I went into the office one day with just the very senior partners," another young consultant told Mari. "They asked me whether I was interested in working on something new ... And then they just said, 'Well, it's tobacco. Are you going to work for this or not?' ... You don't really feel able to say no."

Others say there is leeway at certain firms, which let staffers set boundaries. "You also don't want anyone who doesn't believe in the client," the first consultant said, while a third public affairs worker

advised younger colleagues who might have concerns about a particular client: “You have a lot more leverage than you think.”

No-go zones: The most frequently cited red lines among the consultants POLITICO spoke to were the tobacco, oil, alcohol, defense and gambling industries, plus the far right, Russian interests and Chinese companies. The first consultant said she turned down a fossil fuels client after a decade in the business. How did that go down? “I was fired.”

Are there sectors that don’t have the same reputational risk? “I’ve never met anyone doing financial lobbying that has any qualms about it,” the first consultant said. “I think it’s because there’s so much f\*cking money.”

**\*\*Don’t miss out on our AIQ webinar, where we discuss key life sciences deliverables and deadlines expected from European regulators, so you can plan your next move with confidence. Sign up now .\*\***

## 6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

IN THE BUNKER: Donald Trump is heading to Ireland this weekend on a grand golf trip that’s got officials fretting about the potential for a diplomatic screwup , Shawn Pogatchnik writes.

BRING IN EPPO: Kaja Kallas wants the EU’s prosecutors to be given responsibility for bringing cases against individuals and companies that help Russia get around sanctions.

FARAGE AND FRIENDS: Nigel Farage is looking for candidates to stand in a general election that Reform UK has a shot at winning — but it’s not as easy as you’d think, Sam Blewett writes.

YOU’VE GOT A FRIEND IN ME: Mark Carney pledged that Canada will help Ukraine bolster its air defenses and replenish its drone stocks as he hosted President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Calgary, the Guardian reports.

MEANWHILE, IN PARIS: Economist Gabriel Zucman told POLITICO he has invited U.S. Sen. Bernie Sanders and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez to a summit on fiscal justice on Nov. 21 .

IN SPACE, NO ONE CAN HEAR YOU REGULATE: Europe wants to go further into space. In this week’s Declassified column, Paul Dallison imagines what that might look like .

## BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy with some light rain around. High of 21C.

SPRITZ MISTO, PART 2: Remember the spritz misto saga ? The cocktail MEP Brando Benifei ordered at the Italian Republic Day party — only to leave the bartender stumped over how to make it. But at Spirits Europe’s reception, Campari’s Enrico Bocedi confirmed to Playbook that the drink exists, particularly in Milan and northern Italy, where it’s better known as mezzo e mezzo — literally “half and half,” for its equal parts Campari and Aperol.

It’s not official, though: It hasn’t made the International Bartenders Association’s official cocktail list, Bocedi explained. Yes, cocktails are codified: There are now more than 100 on the IBA list, divided into three categories.

SPOTTED ... at the closing reception of Spirit of Life Week at Bump Policy Experience Space — complete with an alcohol tester to check your consumption on the way out: Brewers of Europe's Simon Spillane; Pernod Ricard's José Ramón Fernández Barrero; spiritsEUROPE's Carole Brigaudeau and Pauline Bastidon; World Federation of Advertisers' Alexandre Boyer; Waterloo Gin's Edward Martin; Comité Européen des Entreprises Vins' Ignacio Sánchez Recarte; MTK's Max Schulman; Campari's Enrico Bocedi and Claudia Resmini; ETC's Eduardo Santander; International Bartenders Association's Serge Guillou; and POLITICO's Agnes Rønberg and Gerardo Fortuna.

THERE'S A NEW PARTY MAGAZINE IN TOWN: MEPs Sandro Gozi and Lukas Sieper yesterday unveiled *Democrats Review*, a new magazine from the European Democratic Party's think tank. The launch edition features essays by jailed Turkish opposition leader Ekrem İmamoğlu, former French PM François Bayrou and Venezuelan opposition leader María Corina Machado.

URBAN PLAYGROUND: Starting today, Brussels Urban Sessions takes over Cinquantenaire Park through Sunday for its fifth edition, bringing together some of the world's top BMX riders, skateboarders and parkour athletes, plus 3×3 basketball, street art, live performances and DJ sets.

SABLON TREASURE HUNT: A Brussels classic returns today, the Sablon Design Market, running through Sunday with 50 exhibitors showing off vintage furniture, jewelry, lamps, luggage, home decor and artisan finds. Best of all? It's free.

RAISE A GLASS: Celebrate 10 years since Belgian beer culture was granted UNESCO status by heading to the Belgian Beer Culture Bar pop-up on Place de la Bourse, with 40 beers on tap. Or try Wanderlust by Brussels Beer Project at the Fish Market on Saturday and Sunday, with more than 10 breweries, around 50 beers, street food and DJ sets.

CATS OUT: The Belgian Cats are out of the Women's Basketball World Cup after their quarterfinal defeat, but the tournament rolls on with the semifinals and final this weekend. Catch the remaining action at Brussels' first pop-up bar dedicated to women's sport, in the Stalingrad area, with big-screen games, DJs and community events.

LAST PICTURE SHOW: The Brussels International Film Festival wraps up tomorrow. There's still time to catch screenings at UGC De Brouckère, Cinéma Galeries and Cinéma Palace — including plenty of discoveries and out-of-competition picks.

## TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The prospect of another CDU failure in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern is fueling more talk of Friedrich Merz stepping aside.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron and Sébastien Lecornu are at odds over the timetable for passing the budget, with the president keen to have it wrapped up before his final New Year's Eve address.

London: A controversial assisted dying bill is back in the Commons, but Andy Burnham is noticeably cooler on the legislation than his predecessor.

Washington: Thousands of Salvadoran immigrants in the Washington area are in legal limbo, waiting to learn whether they'll keep their temporary protected status.

Canberra: Parliament's sitting week descended into a four-day circus of unhinged tiffs, rants and messaging backflips.

## AGENDA

- Coreper I meets in Brussels at 9:30 a.m.
- European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen receives members of Coreper for a working lunch.
- European Parliament President Roberta Metsola participates in the G7 Speakers' Meeting in Paris, where she delivers a speech at the inaugural session at 9:30 a.m.; meets French President Emmanuel Macron at 11:50 a.m.; meets Ukrainian Parliament Speaker Ruslan Stefanchuk at 5:45 p.m.; and participates in a flame rekindling ceremony at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier at 6:30 p.m.
- Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen delivers a keynote speech at Ireland's presidency conference on children and young people's experiences online and online safety.
- Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera meets the head of the Croatian Competition Agency in Zagreb.
- Equality Commissioner Hadja Lahbib meets Moldovan President Maia Sandu in Chişinău.
- Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius participates in the first board meeting of the EU-Ukraine Drone Alliance at 9 a.m. Follow live .
- Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen meets French Agriculture Minister Annie Genevard.
- Sport Commissioner Glenn Micallef attends the opening ceremony of the Special Olympics European Swimming Open in Msida, Malta.
- NATO Deputy Secretary-General Radmila Shekerinska joins U.S. officials at NATO headquarters in Brussels to commemorate the 25th anniversary of the Sept. 11 terrorist attacks.
- Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in a discussion at the Riga Conference on EU competitiveness two years after the Draghi report, with U.S. Ambassador to the EU Andrew Puzder.

## BIRTHDAYS

MEP Dan-Ştefan Motreanu; former MEPs Maria Spyrali, Dino Giarrusso, Laura Ferrara, Miroslav Mikolášik and Kerstin Westphal; POLITICO's Joe Schatz; New Music Dublin's Francine Cunningham; Czechia's Permanent Representative to the OECD Aleš Chmelař; former European Green Party Secretary-General Mar García; journalist Caroline de Gruyter; former Syrian dictator Bashar Assad. National Day of Catalonia.

Celebrating Saturday: MEP Adam Bielan; former MEPs Bogusław Liberadzki, Francisco Guerreiro, Mark Demesmaecker and Lidia Joanna Geringer de Oedenberg; German politician Sigmar Gabriel; De huisartsenconnectie's Arjan van 't Veer; hub.brussels' Jutta Buyse; Covington's Bart Szewczyk; Coimbra Group's Rúben Castro; former Irish Taoiseach Bertie Ahern.

Celebrating Sunday: National Rally President Jordan Bardella; MEPs Csaba Dömötör and Lina Gálvez Muñoz; former MEPs Włodzimierz Cimoszewicz, Claude Gruffat, Sophie in 't Veld, Paul Brannen and Jarosław Wałęsa; Salva Kiir Mayardit, president of South Sudan.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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